How to mix the colour and its shades

In an ordinary painting set blue is one of the basic colours. The easiest start is a blue from a tube and the search for its shades. From yellow and red alone you will not get a pure blue. The proportions are only approximate and every brand behaves a little differently, so **try them out** on paper first.

What to prepare



Ultramarine blue
The starting blue for mixes towards violet.



Cyan
Cool, light, airy.



Burnt umber
Mutes and deepens.



Violet
For ink-like and deeper blues.



White
Lightens it and reveals the tint of the dark colour.



Phthalo blue (green shade)
For azure and blue-green tones; it stains very strongly.



Magenta
By the tip, when you want to push blue towards violet.



Phthalo green
For petrol and sea mixes.



Orange
The opposite of blue on the colour wheel; it mutes it.

Can blue be made from two colours after all?

Yes, when working with cyan and magenta **you can** mix blue to blue-violet tones. It depends on the actual pigments, their strength and the proportion. Such a mix is not automatically the same as an ultramarine or cobalt from a tube, it tends to be slightly different. **Try** it as an experiment, not as a substitute.

How to recognise it without technical names

On the tube look for the marking PB (Pigment Blue) and a number. It tells you which pigment it is, even when the name differs. For example PB29 is ultramarine, PB15 phthalo blue and PB28 cobalt. A ready-made blue **you can** buy from a tube, but you can also shift it wherever you need.

Ultramarine suits as a starting blue for mixes towards violet. A phthalo blue with a green tint works well towards azure and blue-green tones and can stain very strongly. First **try** one small pile and only then add more.

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What the additions do



White

Lightens and pushes towards sky and pastel. Add it little by little.





Cyan

Refreshes, lifts towards the sky and towards turquoise.





Violet

Deepens towards ink and evening blue.





Phthalo green

Leads to petrol and sea. A strong pigment, add it carefully.





Burnt umber

Mutes and deepens. Denim, smoky. You easily add too much of it.





Orange

The opposite of blue. It mutes it; a bigger dose pulls it towards grey-brown.



Ten blues to try

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Ten blues to try – continued

A part means an equally sized dose of paint. A drop, a pinch or a pile. Take the proportions as a starting point for trying. With a strong phthalo blue much less may be enough. Try small mixes and write down the names of the tubes. Samples show an approximate impression, on paper they turn out differently.

Sky

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ + ■

4 parts white + about 1 part ultramarine. Add the blue into the white. When the tint is too violet, **try** a dot of cyan.

Lavender blue

☐ ☐ ☐ + ■ + ●

3 parts white + 1 part ultramarine + a trace of magenta. If you want to stay with blue, add the magenta only by the tip.

Smoky blue

☐ ☐ ☐ + ■ + ●

3 parts white + 1 part ultramarine + a small dot of burnt umber. First mix a light blue and only then mute it carefully.

Petrol

■ ■ + ■

2 parts phthalo blue + gradually up to 1 part phthalo green. Both colours can be strong. A little white will show their tint.

Turquoise

■ + ■ + ☐

1 part blue + 1 part green + a little white. Fresh, sea-like, a bit playful. The proportion is from the original card.

Cornflower

☐ ☐ + ■ + ●

2 parts white + 1 part ultramarine; a dot of magenta if needed. **Try** the magenta first in a small part of the mix.

Denim

■ ■ + ☐ + ●

2 parts ultramarine + 1 part white + a tiny bit of burnt umber. The brown mix mutes; it is easy to add too much.

Navy

■ ■ ■ + ●

3 parts ultramarine; burnt umber little by little. Judge the darkness also in a thin layer on white paper.

Ink

■ ■ ■ + ■

3 parts ultramarine + up to 1 part violet; possibly a trace of umber. Violet deepens it, umber mutes. Add each separately.

Midnight

■ ■ ■ ■ + ●

roughly 10 parts ultramarine + 1 part burnt umber or a drop of red. Deep, **quiet**, mysterious. A pure black would rather dirty it. The proportion is my approximate suggestion.

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When blue does not fit

Too green? **Try** a trace of magenta in a separate small dose. Too violet? **Try** cyan. Too garish? Mute with a small amount of a suitable orange or brown. Too dark? White will lighten it and make it more pastel. Saturate it only at the end.

With transparent watercolour lightness is also made by paper showing through. White from a tube changes the character of the mix. Let samples dry; wet and dry paint may not look the same.

When you mix more than three colours in one mix, it often turns to mud. That happens to every one of us.

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